

The Honesty Matrix: A Stipulative Two-Dimensional Typology of Truthful and Untruthful Utterances

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Abstract

We propose the *Honesty Matrix*, a compact 2×2 typology that classifies declarative utterances along two independent axes: (i) the *truth-value* of the utterance with respect to the actual state of affairs, and (ii) the speaker’s *awareness* of the full epistemic and consequential status of that utterance at the moment of speaking. The model is presented as a *stipulative* framework, not as a redefinition of the philosophical notion of lying. It is intended to organise familiar phenomena — sincere truth-telling, deliberate deception, the Freudian slip, the white lie, the honest mistake, and Frankfurtian bullshit — inside a single, explicit structure. We give precise working definitions, place the framework relative to existing accounts in philosophy of lying and psychoanalysis, work each cell through with examples, sketch a minimal operationalisation, and state the model’s limitations.

Keywords: honesty, lying, deception, sincerity, accuracy, consciousness, self-deception, Freudian slip, bullshit, typology.

1 Introduction

Standard philosophical analyses of lying require three elements: the speaker makes a statement, believes it to be false, and intends to deceive the hearer [1, 3, 8, 4]. This belief-centred account captures the paradigmatic lie but leaves several familiar phenomena underdescribed: utterances whose truth-value the speaker has not consciously considered (e.g. slips of the tongue [6]); utterances whose content is technically true but produced without deliberate intent; “socially benign” falsehoods whose downstream consequences are unknown [3]; assertions produced with indifference to truth [5]; and deceptive communication achieved without uttering any literal falsehood [10, 7].

This paper does not contest the standard definition of lying. Instead, it introduces a *descriptive typology of utterances* — the Honesty Matrix — that adds an explicit *awareness* dimension to the truth-value axis already implicit in the literature. The matrix is stipulative: its cells are defined by the axes, not by appeal to ordinary usage. Its purpose is taxonomic clarity rather than conceptual revision.

The closest precursor is Williams’s distinction between the two “virtues of truth”: *Sincerity* (saying what one believes) and *Accuracy* (taking due care that one’s beliefs are true) [13]. The Honesty Matrix can be read as a discretised cousin of that view: the content axis tracks accuracy of the utterance, while the awareness axis tracks something closely related to — though broader than — sincerity. Related contemporary treatments include Carson’s [4] warranting account of lying, Sorensen’s [11] discussion of bald-faced lies, and Stokke’s [12] insincerity-based analysis. The present contribution is the explicit 2×2 tabulation, the acknowledgement of an *unconscious* mode of utterance on the speaker’s side, and the mapping of familiar phenomena onto the resulting four cells.

2 Definitions

We adopt the following working definitions. They are stipulative within this paper; alternative definitions exist and are discussed in Section 8.

Utterance. A declarative statement made by a speaker with assertoric force.

Truth-value (content axis). An utterance is *true* if it corresponds to the actual state of affairs, and *false* otherwise. We use “lie” in this paper as a short label for “false utterance” — a deliberate terminological simplification that diverges from the philosophical mainstream (cf. Section 8). Correspondence is assumed only as a working assumption.

Awareness (epistemic axis). A speaker is *conscious* of an utterance when, at the moment of speaking, they have deliberate access to (a) its intended content, (b) its truth-value relative to their own beliefs, and (c) its foreseeable consequences. If any of these is absent, the speaker is, to that extent, *unconscious* of the utterance.

Two notes on the awareness axis. First, “unconscious” is used in a broad psychological sense (lack of deliberate access), not strictly the Freudian technical sense; it is closer to Block’s notion of failure of *access consciousness* [2]. Second, awareness is treated as binary here for classificatory simplicity; a graded version is a natural extension and is briefly discussed in Section 8.

3 The Matrix

Crossing the two axes yields the four cells in Table 1. Each cell name is a label internal to this paper; correspondences to ordinary language are discussed in Section 4 and illustrated by examples in Section 5.

Table 1: The Honesty Matrix.

	Conscious	Unconscious
True	Sincere truth-telling	Unintended truth
False	Deliberate lie	Unwitting falsehood

Sincere truth-telling. The utterance is true, and the speaker has deliberate access to its content, truth-value, and likely consequences. This is the prototype of honesty.

Deliberate lie. The utterance is false, and the speaker is aware of its falsity and of its intended deceptive function. This matches the standard philosophical definition of lying [8, 4].

Unintended truth. The utterance is true, but the speaker did not deliberately intend to assert it as such — e.g. a slip of the tongue that happens to state a fact, or an offhand remark that turns out to be veridical.

Unwitting falsehood. The utterance is false, but the speaker lacks full deliberate access to its falsity, its consequences, or both. The clearest occupants are sincere errors and certain forms of self-deception [9].

4 Mapping Familiar Phenomena

4.1 Freudian slip → Unintended truth

A parapraxis, in psychoanalytic theory, is a verbal error read as the surfacing of unconscious material [6]. Independently of whether one accepts the psychoanalytic mechanism, the linguistic

structure of such slips fits the *unintended truth* cell whenever the slip happens to state something the speaker would not have deliberately asserted but which is, in fact, the case. We make no claim about the empirical frequency or psychological cause of such slips.

4.2 Honest mistake and self-deception → Unwitting falsehood

A speaker who sincerely asserts a falsehood they believe to be true is classified here as producing an *unwitting falsehood*. The same cell hosts cases of self-deception, in which a speaker sincerely asserts what, on some deeper level, they have reason to doubt or disbelieve [9].

4.3 The white lie: a boundary case

The *white lie* is conventionally a falsehood the speaker knows to be false but believes to be socially harmless [3]. Under the definitions adopted here it sits *between* the deliberate lie (the speaker is aware of the falsity) and the unwitting falsehood (the speaker is typically unaware of the lie’s full long-term consequences). It is therefore best treated as a boundary case rather than a clean occupant of either cell. The matrix does not aim to dissolve this tension; it makes it explicit.

4.4 Bullshit: a phenomenon the matrix does not capture

Frankfurt’s [5] bullshitter is characterised by *indifference* to truth-value, not by unawareness of it. Bullshit is therefore not a clean occupant of any cell of the present matrix: it represents a third epistemic stance — neither believing-true nor believing-false — and would require a richer awareness axis (or an explicit “indifference” attitude) to be modelled directly. We note this as a known incompleteness of the model.

4.5 Deception without lying

A speaker can deceive while uttering only true sentences — through conversational implicature, selective emphasis, misleading omission, or strategic silence [7, 10]. Such cases lie outside the scope of the matrix: the literal-content axis cannot capture them. The matrix is best read as covering *assertoric* dishonesty, not the wider category of *deceptive communication*.

4.6 Irony, fiction, and performatives

Ironic, fictional, and performative utterances have literal contents whose truth-value diverges from what is asserted. We follow standard practice [7] in treating these as cases in which assertoric force is suspended or shifted; they fall outside the matrix because no straightforward truth-value evaluation of the literal content applies.

5 Worked Examples

The following four examples instantiate one occupant of each cell. They are illustrative, not empirical.

Sincere truth-telling (True, Conscious).

A witness on the stand, having clearly recalled an event and intending to convey what they remember, states, “The car was red.” The car was, in fact, red.

Deliberate lie (False, Conscious).

A defendant, knowing he was at the scene, states, “I was at home that evening,” intending the court to believe him.

Unintended truth (True, Unconscious).

A spouse means to say “I’ll be at the office” but accidentally says “I’ll be at the bar.” They are, in fact, going to the bar, though they did not consciously intend to disclose this.

Unwitting falsehood (False, Unconscious).

A speaker confidently asserts “The capital of Australia is Sydney,” sincerely believing it, unaware that the capital is Canberra.

6 Operationalisation

The matrix is conceptual, but a minimum procedure for assigning a given utterance u produced by speaker S to a cell can be stated:

1. Determine the truth-value of u relative to the actual state of affairs. If unavailable, cell assignment along the content axis is suspended and the matrix is silent on u until further evidence is obtained.
2. Determine, from S ’s subsequent reports, behaviour, and background beliefs, whether S had deliberate access to (a) the intended content of u , (b) its truth-value relative to S ’s own beliefs, and (c) its foreseeable consequences. Full deliberate access on all three places u in the conscious row; failure on any one places u in the unconscious row.
3. If u is non-assertoric (ironic, fictional, performative) or achieves its communicative effect via implicature rather than literal content, mark u as out of scope.

The procedure is fallible: step 2 depends on testimony or inference about a speaker’s mental state, which is rarely decisive, and any graded notion of awareness will yield borderline cases. The procedure nevertheless makes the matrix’s cell assignments in principle checkable rather than purely declarative.

7 Discussion

Three observations follow from the matrix.

Honesty is not one-dimensional. Two utterances with identical truth-value can occupy different cells depending on the speaker’s awareness; two utterances at the same awareness level can differ in truth-value. Any single-axis evaluation of “honesty” therefore omits information.

Truth can be incidental. The *unintended truth* cell shows that veridical speech is not, by itself, evidence of deliberate honesty.

Sincere assertion does not guarantee truth. The *unwitting falsehood* cell shows the converse: deliberate honesty is not evidence of veridical speech. Both observations are consistent with the standard epistemological distinction between knowledge and justified belief, and with knowledge-norm accounts of assertion [14].

8 Limitations and Scope

The matrix is deliberately narrow. The following limitations apply.

1. **Stipulative definitions.** The use of “lie” for any false utterance (rather than a belief-and-intent-laden notion) is a terminological choice for this paper. Readers preferring the standard definition can substitute “false utterance” for “lie” throughout without loss.
2. **Binary axes.** Truth-value and awareness are both treated as binary. Real cases are graded (partial truths, partial awareness); the binary form is a simplification. Graded axes would yield a continuous version of the matrix [2].
3. **Correspondence assumption.** The content axis assumes a correspondence-style notion of truth. Coherence- or pragmatist-style accounts would reshape the content axis but leave the awareness axis intact.
4. **Partial axis coupling.** The axes are presented as independent, but “deliberate lie” presupposes awareness of falsity by definition. The independence claim is therefore descriptive, not strictly logical.
5. **Assertoric scope.** The matrix covers declarative assertions only. Lying by omission, misleading implicature, irony, fiction, and performative utterances fall outside its scope [10, 7].
6. **Indifference not modelled.** Frankfurtian bullshit [5] — assertion without regard to truth — is not captured by a binary awareness axis.
7. **No empirical claims.** The mapping of Freudian slips, white lies, and self-deception to particular cells is conceptual, not empirical. No claim is made about how often such utterances occur or about their underlying psychological mechanisms.
8. **Moral neutrality.** The matrix classifies utterances; it does not assign blame or praise. Moral evaluation typically depends on awareness, but is left to ethical theory.

9 Conclusion

The Honesty Matrix is a small, explicit, stipulative typology. It crosses the truth-value of an utterance with the speaker’s awareness of that utterance’s status and identifies four cells: *sincere truth-telling*, *unintended truth*, *deliberate lie*, and *unwitting falsehood*. Familiar phenomena — the Freudian slip, the honest mistake, the white lie, and Frankfurtian bullshit — can be located, partially located, or explicitly recognised as out of scope within this structure. The framework is offered as an organising tool, compatible with rather than competing against established accounts of lying, deception, self-deception, and parapraxis, and its limitations are stated openly.

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